

# **The Little Cardinal's Promise**

# **THE LITTLE CARDINAL'S PROMISE**

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The Little Cardinal's Promise

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*For the ones watching the windows.*





At first, it was just the two of them.

Rob and Mama.

Mama and Rob.



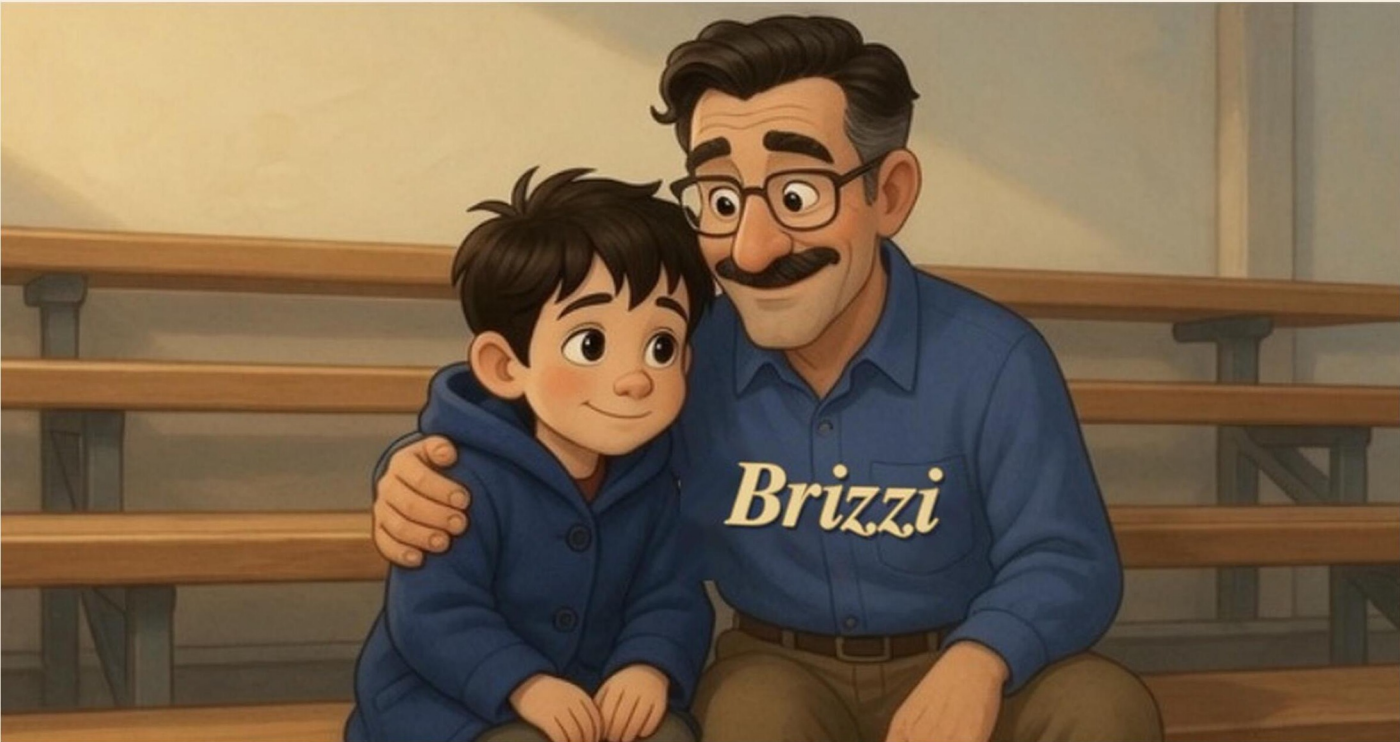
Rob's dad was the kind of dad  
who showed up —  
in his blue shirt, arms open,  
every single time.



He came to the games Rob won,  
and the games Rob lost.

Always in the third row.

Blue shirt. Arms crossed. Watching. Proud.



Saturdays were for fly balls.  
A hundred of them, then a hundred more.

“One more,” Dad always said,  
kneeling in the grass with that proud smile.







Dad made one promise, and only one.

“No matter what,” he said, kneeling with the ball,  
“I will always show up for you.”



When Rob grew up, he moved far away —  
all the way to California.

Dad stayed. Dad watched. Dad waited.

Promises don't mind the miles.



Dad's old blue shirt was too big...  
but Rob wore it anyway.

It still smelled like Saturday mornings.





One winter, Dad got sick.  
His naps got longer. His voice got softer.

But when Rob sat beside him,  
Dad still smiled the smile that meant:  
you're mine, and I'm glad.





“Then who will show up for me?” Rob asked.

Dad heard him. He held out his hand.

“Watch for me,” Dad whispered.

“I keep my promises.”



Dad died on a snowy day.  
The house got quiet. The truck stayed parked.

Rob didn't want breakfast.  
He didn't want fly balls.  
He didn't want anything at all.



The quiet stayed a long time.





One cold morning, Rob heard a tap.

Tap. Tap-tap.



On the window sat a bird.  
Not a brown bird. Not a gray bird.  
A bright red bird. Red as Dad's truck.

It looked right at Rob.  
And it stayed.



“Mama!” Rob whispered.

“It's not flying away!”

Mama knelt beside him,  
and her eyes went shiny.

“You know what some people say about red birds,” she said.

“They say a cardinal is how love shows up... after.”



Rob put his hand against the cold glass.  
“You came,” he said, eyes shining.  
“You kept your promise.”

The cardinal tipped its head —  
the exact way Dad did  
when he was proud and didn't say so.

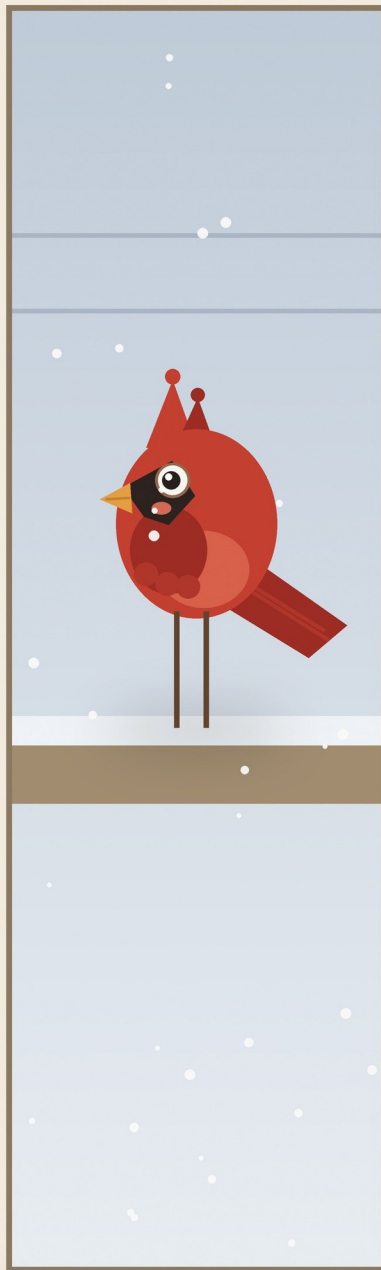




The cardinal didn't come every day.  
But it came.

On the first day of school.  
At the last game of the season.

On days when Rob missed Dad  
so much his chest hurt —  
tap. Tap-tap.



Now, when the world feels too quiet...  
watch the windows.

Red keeps its promises.



And when the cardinal came,  
Rob always said the same thing.

“I see you. I love you too.”

Because love that shows up  
never stops showing up.  
It just changes where it sits.





Now, when the world feels too quiet...  
watch the windows.  
Watch the fences and the branches and the snow.  
  
Red keeps its promises.



## A NOTE FOR GROWN-UPS

When you talk with a child about death,  
use the real words.  
Say died, not went to sleep.

Let them see that you miss the person too;  
grief shared is grief halved,  
even for the smallest hearts.

And when a red bird lands, let it be a comfort  
without being a test.  
The point was never the bird.

The point is that love that showed up  
keeps showing up.  
It just changes where it sits.

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